

Possible topic exploration:

Select a topic from your brainstorming activities. Find two or three academic articles, studies, or sources that seem important for researching this topic.

List the proper citations for the sources:

A friend of mine created his own YouTube channel, and then began creating video content based upon my game, and no matter how many videos he uploaded he could never generate enough views to make his video get recognized by anybody else. Other content creators were able to create similar types of content and receive a significant amount of attention very quickly, and I believe that this happened simply because his YouTube Channel was still relatively young and therefore the algorithm didn't think that there was value in promoting the content he was uploading. This experience caused me to consider how algorithms determine who gets to see your content, and at what point the process of determining who sees your content may ultimately exclude certain people.

Gillespie, T. (2014). The Relevance of Algorithms. In T. Gillespie, P. J. Boczkowski, & K. A. Foot (Eds.), *Media Technologies: Essays on Communication, Materiality, and Society* (pp. 167-194). MIT Press.

Noble, S. U. (2018). *Algorithms of Oppression: How Search Engines Reinforce Racism*. NYU Press.

Bucher, T. (2012). Want to Be on Top? Algorithmic Power and the Threat of Invisibility on Facebook. *New Media & Society*, 14(7), 1164-1180.

What research questions do these sources attempt to answer?

Gillespie wants to know what it means when algorithms act as gatekeepers to public discourse and why we treat them as neutral even though they are not. Noble wants to find out how search engines, specifically Google, support racism and sexism, and what occurs when you search for Black women and girls online. Bucher wants to find out how individuals react and interact with each other when they understand that an algorithm is probably excluding some of their content from being viewed by other users. Ultimately, all three authors want to identify who has visibility online and who doesn't.

What methodology do these researchers use to answer their research questions?

Gillespie's primary methodology involves using theory, drawing on science and technology studies to develop a framework of thought about algorithms as political actors rather than just tools. Noble develops his methodology through a combination of hands-on research and critical race theory; he searches specific terms using Google and documents the results that reflect biased outcomes. Bucher conducts interviews with Facebook users to document their experiences with the News Feed algorithm, and frames those experiences in terms of Foucault's concepts of surveillance to explain how users begin to alter their behaviors once they realize they are being sorted.

What conversation are these sources having? Where might your research fit into this conversation (the gap)?

All three authors are discussing how algorithms decide who gets to see content and what occurs as a result of that decision-making. Gillespie provides a base for serious consideration of algorithms as powerful institutions. Noble demonstrates the impact of that power in the form of bias against people of color. Bucher provides a personal view of how users feel anxious and begin to modify their actions when they suspect that their content is being excluded from visibility by an algorithm. There is one omission in this discussion that I have identified as being missing from this conversation regarding whether or not individuals are entitled to visibility online. While these scholars describe the issue clearly, none of the authors move toward stating that platforms may owe users fair access to seeing content.

How do you think your own research findings will relate to these readings or sources? For example, you may anticipate that your research will:

- a. Build on, extend, or add to this existing research.
- b. Poke holes in or challenge this existing research. Do you question some of the assumptions in this existing research?
- c. Shed new light on an issue or problem because you plan to use different methods. How might your research complement this existing work?
- d. Apply some of the methods or principles in this literature to a different context.
- e. Fill some kind of “gap” in the literature or help answer a pressing question in the field – perhaps as identified in these pieces. How might your work inform current debates?

My goal is to build upon the foundations established by these authors. Gillespie provided me with the basis for considering algorithms as political and I want to expand on that by exploring the rights that users should possess as a response. Noble’s documentation of the fact that the greatest harm from algorithms falls most heavily on the members of marginalized groups will assist me in connecting his work to newer policy discussions that he was not able to discuss thoroughly. Bucher’s interviews motivate me to speak to content creators that believe they have been unfairly overlooked by algorithms and provide real voices to the theoretical work that currently exists. I also believe that a rights-based approach could be a more effective means of achieving actual policy changes than Bucher’s use of a surveillance theory approach, not because the latter is incorrect but because the former may be a more practical means of producing something concrete. Ultimately, my project is attempting to answer the question raised by the authors and left unanswered by the authors: If algorithms function as unfair gatekeepers, what do individuals deserve in return?